

Unveiling Signification: The Semiotics of Digital Calligraffiti as a Performative Research Tool into the Ghent Paradox

1. Abstract

This practice based PhD research looks into the spatial and political friction of Arabic script within European urban landscapes. I am focusing on what I call the Ghent Paradox. This is a lived institutional contradiction where my digital calligraffiti was abruptly censored as a security threat at the Gravensteen castle in 2021, only to be monumentally commissioned by Viernulvier in 2025. This project bridges cinematic storytelling and institutional critique by using the Infl3ctor, which is a custom built handheld projection device. I do not see it as a simple display tool but as an audiovisual epistemic probe. Through performative interventions in contested public spaces in Belgium, this research provokes and dissects the invisible borders of bureaucratic authority. The methodology relies on reflexive documentary practices to capture the moment of friction between the artist physical gesture and the materiality of architecture under the policing gaze. The primary output of this research will be a feature-length reflexive documentary film and a visual Tactical Manual.

The cinematic apparatus is the central research framework. The documentary component is not a mere mode of documentation for a visual art piece, but the actual site of knowledge production.

Together, these outputs aim to provide transnational artists with a rigorous framework for navigating and subverting the semiotics of European public space.

2. Research Context and Urgency

The urgency of this project comes directly from the changing reality of European public spaces. Right now the physical skin of our cities is heavily monitored and politically contested. As Scott McQuire argues in his analysis of the media city the architecture and urban spaces we inhabit are increasingly defined by digital networks and screens. Within this monitored environment the Arabic script often triggers immediate bureaucratic and security responses when it appears in the public domain. But as I experienced firsthand with the Ghent Paradox the exact same visual language can be celebrated as monumental art if it passes through the right institutional filters.

To navigate this I rely on Digital Calligraffiti. Initiated in 2017 by Public Art Lab and From Here to Fame Publishing House this movement aims to transform the urban ecosystem into a canvas of expression by bringing together traditional calligraffiti and media art. As Susa Pop and her colleagues have explored urban media art possesses a unique capacity to address flaming political and socio cultural topics. Digital Calligraffiti expands on this by animating the creation of tags and projecting them onto urban facades. It uses the memorial aesthetics of writing to catalyze communication and bridge building.

For over fifteen years I have navigated the borders between contested public spaces and cinematic storytelling. Working within the art departments of feature films like *Infidel* and serving as a production

designer for short films like Nemshi I learned exactly how physical spaces and textures dictate human narratives. I want to transition from simply creating public interventions to actively documenting and analyzing them through a cinematic lens. This research will decode the mechanisms of authorized resistance and provide a tested tactical framework for transnational artists navigating the invisible borders of European bureaucracy.

3. Methodology

My research follows a practice based methodology where the artistic act is the primary site of knowledge production. At its core, my approach relies on performative cinema, where the street serves as a live set. Within this framework, the Infl3ctor - which I co created with Michael Ang specifically for Digital Calligraffiti to bridge the gap between the analogue and the digital - functions as an active prop. While the calligraphy is composed and projected in real time offering individuals a moment of expression with high visibility, it is the camera that acts as the primary epistemic probe. I will conduct a series of performative interventions in contested urban sites across Belgium, utilizing the cinematic apparatus to actively capture and dissect the policing gaze and institutional friction.

The methodology also incorporates an advanced technological layer inspired by my current work with creative AI and autonomous workflows. I will use large language models and custom datasets to process and analyze municipal laws and public space regulations across European cities. By training models on archival data of censorship and bureaucratic permits I want to map the patterns of institutional authorization. This allows me to treat the city not just as a physical environment but as a data

landscape where the friction between art and law can be predicted and navigated.

I am also very interested in the peer coaching system offered at RITCS. Engaging with other researchers will help me refine the narrative structure of my reflexive documentary. The academic grounding of this work will involve preparing submissions for peer reviewed journals such as JAR and FORUM+. I want to ensure that the visual data captured through the camera and the AI analysis is translated into a critical discourse that challenges existing semiotic theories of public space.

4. Research Objectives

The main goal of this research is to move beyond the aesthetic side of my work and understand its political and technological life. I have set out a few clear objectives to guide this process. First I want to decode the Ghent Paradox by analyzing the specific moments when Arabic digital calligraffiti transitions from being a perceived threat to becoming a commissioned piece of heritage.

Secondly I aim to establish the Infl3ctor as a legitimate tool for cinematic and urban research. This involves the production of a feature-length reflexive documentary film that analyzes the relationship between the body of the artist and the bureaucratic gaze of the state.

Finally I want to develop a Smart Tactical Manual. Unlike traditional guides I aim to build this as an interactive web interface powered by AI. This tool will analyze geographical risk points and municipal legal frameworks in real time. It will provide transnational artists with actionable data to navigate censorship and find strategic locations for public interventions. I want this

research to provide a tangible and living tool for future artistic resistance in the digital age.

5. Artistic, Technological, and Academic Outcomes

The outcomes of this PhD are designed to be multifaceted, bridging the gap between cinematic art, interactive technology, and academic discourse. I have structured these outputs to ensure the research has a lasting impact both within the university and in the hands of practicing artists.

On the artistic and technological side, the primary outcome will be a feature length reflexive documentary film. This film will synthesize my field research, the physical interventions with the Infl3ctor, and the bureaucratic correspondence into a cohesive cinematic narrative. I am aware of the artistic production budget provided by RITCS and I plan to utilize it to support the shooting and post production phases of this work. Alongside the film, I will develop the Smart Tactical Manual. This project evolves my previous work with narrative comics like Not Numbers into a functional web application powered by AI. This application will feature an interactive interface that provides real time guidance for artists based on their geographical location and the specific legal context of the urban area. It will function as a digital companion for navigating urban media environments and avoiding censorship.

On the academic side, I am fully committed to the publication standards of VUB and RITCS. I aim to produce A1 peer reviewed articles that reflect on the methodology, the semiotic findings of the Infl3ctor interventions, and the innovative application of AI in mapping institutional resistance. My primary target platforms for these publications are FORUM+ and JAR which is the Journal for Artistic Research. These platforms are perfectly suited for practice based research and will allow me to share my cinematic and technological analysis with the wider academic community. This

comprehensive approach ensures that the research remains artistically rigorous, technologically innovative, and academically valid.

6. Work Plan and Timeline

I have structured my research over a four year period to allow for a deep integration of artistic practice and academic reflection. My plan follows the requirements of the VUB and RITCS doctoral trajectory.

Year 1: Foundation and Initial Mapping My first year will focus on establishing the theoretical framework and mapping the specific urban sites in Ghent and Brussels for my interventions. I will set up my advisory commission and complete the first annual progress report as required by the university. I plan to conduct a series of pilot interventions using the Infl3ctor to test the technical and social responses in different neighborhoods. This year is about laying the ground for the deeper cinematic work.

Year 2: Intensive Field Research and Peer Coaching During the second year I will move into intensive field research. This involves the main cycle of performative interventions and starting the cinematic documentation process. I will actively participate in the peer coaching sessions at RITCS to refine my methodology. My goal for this year is to complete a first draft of an article for JAR or FORUM+ focusing on the early findings of the Ghent Paradox. I will also submit my second progress report to show the evolution of the practice.

Year 3: Production and Synthesis Year three will be dedicated to the production of the feature-length reflexive documentary film. I will utilize the artistic production budget to move into high quality shooting and early

editing stages. While the film is being shaped I will start synthesizing the visual data into the structure of the Tactical Manual. I plan to prepare a second peer reviewed article during this phase that discusses the relationship between the artist body and the policing gaze.

Year 4: Finalization and Defense The final year is about bringing everything together. I will focus on the final editing of the documentary and the completion of the visual Tactical Manual. I will also write the reflexive text that accompanies the artistic work to provide a final academic synthesis. My goal is to submit the final portfolio and prepare for the public defense of the PhD. By the end of this year I want to have a completed body of work that serves both the academic and the artistic community.

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